the blocks quickly. When Covid struck, more than Johnson, Sunak became the man of the moment. His profile soared when he oversaw generous cash schemes and furloughs to help the needy and unemployed, which saw him being acknowledged as a "compassionate leader" even as he took tough decisions to steady the tottering economy.

Simultaneously, Sunak built up his public image, even enlisting the help of Cass Horowitz, co-founder of The Clerkenwell Brothers, an independent creative studio working across strategy, identity, advertising and social media. "The particular approach he and his team took has probably a lot to do with the old advertising idea of positioning—finding a distinct persona within the market—so the slick but homely image that's being pushed for him is different from the belligerent populist images that have dominated politics recently, and has the chance to stand out because of this," says Philip Seargeant, author of *The Art of Political Storytelling: Why Stories Win Votes in Post-Truth Politics*.

FOR THE LABOUR PARTY, SUNAK IS A MORE DIFFICULT OPPONENT THAN OTHER TORY CANDIDATES GIVEN HIS RELATIVE YOUTH, GOOD LOOKS, CHARISMA, CONFIDENCE AND CAN-DO APPROACH

Sunak struck at the right time by resigning from his position as chancellor in July when he found that Johnson's reign had turned chaotic. In a tweet he posted soon after his resignation, he said, "The public rightly expect government to be conducted properly, competently and seriously." His resignation set off a cascade of ministerial departures that culminated in Johnson's ouster. Though losing the leadership race to Truss was a setback, it may have been a blessing in disguise. It gives Sunak more leeway and time to go about pulling the economy out of the morass it has sunk into. Sunak will have to deal with not just an economy in a shambles, but also a Tory party that is hopelessly split into groups and a resurgent Labour party that is demanding fresh general elections rather than wait till 2024. As Sunak told his partymen after being elected, "It's a do or die moment for us."

For the Labour party, Sunak is a more difficult opponent than any other Tory candidate given his charisma, rare confidence and can-do approach in addition to his relative youth and good looks, captured pithily in a tabloid headline that called him "Dishy Rishi". The British media, which can be both brutal and irreverent to politicians, are even talking about how the Labour party is pinning its hopes on an obscure statistic that believes a taller prime ministerial candidate tends to win. Both Labour leader Sir Keir Starmer and Boris Johnson are relatively short, at 5 feet and 8 inches. But the Labour leader is still taller than Rishi's 5 feet, 6 inch height. "Bring on the little Rishi," they say. Rishi can find solace in the fact that one of Britain's longest-serving and most powerful prime ministers, Margaret Thatcher, was just 5 feet 5 inches tall.



TAKING CENTRE STAGE Britain's new prime minister holding his first Cabinet meeting, Oct. 26

Like Thatcher, Sunak has to resort to tough, unconventional measures to deal with a collapsing economy and public confidence. Sunak is not a pragmatic centrist. "Indeed, his ascension represents a triumph for the Conservatives' Thatcherite wing," says George Eaton, senior editor of the *New Statesman*. "Tory members were offered two varieties of neoliberalism: Reaganite tax cuts from Truss or Thatcherite fiscal discipline from Sunak. The implosion of the former has created the ideal pretext for the latter." His major tasks are to control inflation to keep the electorate happy, steady the pound and lower interest rates to get investment going to revive the economy. Economist Nitin Desai says this will require Sunak to take tough decisions, including spending cuts, particularly in the defence budget, if he doesn't want to impose taxes, in addition to other austerity measures. He also has to find ways to restore trade relations with Europe if Britain's economy is to regain its former might.

"The government's long-term borrowing costs, previously close to zero, had risen above 5 per cent by mid-October, even with the Bank of England shoring up demand to keep bond yields down," says Alan Shipman, a senior